



3rd DRYLANDS GLOBAL SCHOOL

FAO -Food and Agriculture Organization

Committee on Forestry Working Group on Dryland Forests and Agrosilvopastoral Systems

3rd Drylands School Concept Note

**Improving the governance of drylands forests, rangelands and
agrosilvopastoral systems.**

7th – 10th July 2025 / Ulaanbaatar – Mongolia



Context

Drylands and rangelands sustain over 2 million people globally, but face challenges from climate change and unsustainable land use. The Food and Agriculture Organization's (FAO) Working Group on Dryland Forests and Agrosilvopastoral Systems (COFO WG), established in 2016, aims to understand and promote good practices for the protection, sustainable management, and restoration of drylands.

Similarly, the International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists (IYRP) 2026, initiated by Mongolia and supported by the European Union and 102 governments, aims to raise awareness and encourage investment in the pastoral livestock sector, sustainable land management, ecosystem



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restoration, and market access. In its 26th session, the FAO Committee on Forestry (COFO) recognized the progress of the COFO WG in dryland restoration and urged it to support the IYRP through cross-regional expertise exchange.

Drylands encompass wide-ranging environmental and socio-economic differences. Governance structure, political stability and therefore sustainability choices may greatly vary across regions and countries, and a context-dependent approach to building the resilience of dryland production systems is needed. As part of this, the COFO WG is working to building resilient drylands by training champions to advocate for transformative dryland management. Champions can facilitate the creation of a shared vision and create a wave of transformation in dryland policymaking and management.

The inaugural Drylands Summer School took place in Amman, Jordan, partnered with different institutions and organizations. The four-day course empowered participants from all dryland regions with tools to enhance dryland resilience, emphasizing context-specific solutions and defining cross-cutting indicators for progress.



The 2nd Drylands Summer School was organized in collaboration with the FAO Kenya office and in partnership with the United Nations Convention to Combat Desertification's (UNCCD) G20 Global Land Initiative, the Community Jameel, the Center for International Forestry Research and World Agroforestry (CIFOR-ICRAF), the World Overview of Conservation Approaches and Technologies (WOCAT), the Swedish University of Agricultural Sciences (SLU), the Jameel Observatory, the Agricultural Research Council of South Africa (ARC-LNR), the International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists (IYRP) 2026, the GEF-7 Sustainable Forest Management Impact Program on Dryland Sustainable Landscapes (DSL-IP), and the Kenya Forest Service.



3rd Drylands School

The third Drylands School will be organized back-to-back with the 4th session of the Committee on Forestry Working Group on Dryland Forests and Agrosilvopastoral Systems (COFO-WG) in Ulaanbaatar from 7 to 10 of July 2025.

The Drylands School will be host by the Government of Mongolia, in partnership with the IYRP Global Community and other international partners, and the collaboration of different organizations from Mongolia.



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The proposed topic for the 3rd Summer School is “**Improving the governance of dryland forests, rangelands and agrosilvopastoral systems**” and will address, under the Drylands Schools transformational approach, critical issues regarding the governance of drylands and rangelands, building over case studies brought by participants and the experience of Mongolia and other neighbor countries.

The responsible, inclusive and equitable governance of land is central to the protection and promotion of human rights, but also to the efforts to avoid, reduce, and reverse land degradation, to implement sustainable land management and restoration initiatives, to improve sustainable food production and livelihoods, and to sustain the social, cultural and economic practices that form the basis for sustainable development.

Objectives

The 3rd Drylands School aims to train practitioners and experts on the transformational approach to dryland resilient systems and build on their capacities to implement it. The objectives are:

- ◆ To bring together 20-25 dryland planners and practitioners to improve knowledge on responsible, inclusive and equitable governance for drylands forests, rangelands and agrosilvopastoral systems.
- ◆ Effectively train experts to assess, evaluate and improve the governance of drylands under participatory, inclusive, gender responsive, and sustainability-oriented approaches.
- ◆ To support peer to peer learning, experience-sharing and capacity-building to acquire the skills and capacities needed to design, implement, facilitate and monitor multiagent inclusive governance initiatives.

Key topics

1. Introduction: key topics, challenges, trends and opportunities around drylands and rangelands governance
2. Principles of inclusive, gender-responsive and equitable governance in drylands
3. Design, implementation and evaluation of drylands governance initiatives
4. Financial support and financial instruments for the governance of drylands
5. Co-construction of knowledge and innovation in governance
6. Traditional and modern governance by indigenous and dryland communities
7. Role of land governance systems in Land degradation Neutrality and ecosystem restoration
8. Case studies, experiences and successful histories

Target Participants

Target participants include experts, practitioners, project managers, M&E specialists and policy makers who have responsibilities in the management of Agrosilvopastoral systems within dryland areas.



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Partners will widely disseminate an open call for participants, and 20-25 participants will be selected based on motivation, capacities, and potential impact, whilst considering gender, geography, and other aspects of diversity.

Participants are required to complete the FAO [Transforming dryland forests and agrosilvopastoral systems course](#), (3h 49m duration), and prepare a generic case study, based on their own work, to capture experiences in the management of agrosilvopastoral systems. A template for their case study will be provided upon selection.

Program Structure

The Drylands School is a professionally facilitated course combining theoretical knowledge with practice-based learning, including group discussions, peer-to-peer learning, field visits and technical lectures. The course is built on the principles of experiential learning, which places the participants' knowledge and experience at the center. Participants will share and critically reflect on their work to develop a deeper understanding of their own projects while learning how to improve the participatory monitoring of their restoration interventions.

The Drylands School will last 4 days, including a field trip. The entire course will be delivered in English. Professional facilitation and learning support will be provided by a team of dryland management experts and specialists from FAO and other partners. The Drylands School will rely on experience-sharing and networking, to ensure that the group stays connected to a growing network of dryland restoration professionals across the world. Support to the network will be provided for continuous post-Drylands School engagement.

After completion of the Drylands School, a certificate of completion will be provided.

[Programme Outline](#) (this is just a brainstorm list to be developed by the partnership)

Day1: Introduction. Key topics of drylands and rangelands governance

- Multifunctionality and diversity of dry agroforestry and pastoral systems
- Mobility (including trans-border)
- Governance of common lands and common resources
- Governance and biodiversity, shared ecosystems, managed habitats, migratory species, ecological connectivity, etc.
- Complex land uses, overlapping rights, land tenure, resources, uses, and interactions.
- Situation of indigenous communities and other local pastoralists
- Governance, land degradation and ecosystem restoration

Day 2: Enabling environments for inclusive, gender-responsive and equitable governance in drylands.

- Principles, guidelines, standards ...
- Governance and land tenure: FAO and the VVGT



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- Policies and legal frameworks, challenges and constraints
- Institutions, mechanisms and processes of inclusive governance
- Key mechanisms of inclusive governance
 - Customary and indigenous governance systems
 - Participatory processes and institutions
 - Adaptive governance and flexible structures
 - Community governance: importance, resources, institutions
 - Integrated Land Use Planning
 - Forest-livestock-agriculture integration and agroforestry

Day 3: Design, implementation and evaluation of drylands governance initiatives

- Overview of drylands governance initiatives
- Critical issues of drylands governance
- Financial support and financial instruments for the governance of drylands
- Co-construction of knowledge and innovation in governance
- Case studies, experiences and successful histories
- Cross-cutting issues
 - LDN and restoration ambition
 - From COP16 to COP 17 through 2026 IYRP

Field day: (organized by the Government of Mongolia). A day with pasture user groups and rangelands stakeholders

- Understand the relationship of communities and their institutions with land and its resources
- Analyze the tenure, access and use rights to the resources and services used by communities to produce food, graze their livestock and maintain their livelihoods.
- Acknowledge how drylands pastoral and silvopastoral governance systems are ruled and the critical role they play in land management, value chains, ecosystem restoration and drylands sustainable production.
- Share experience with local communities to facilitate changes in knowledge, attitudes, and practice amongst participants and stakeholders, particularly targeting policy-making to promote enabling environments for inclusive drylands governance



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Following-up Drylands School

The Drylands Schools is not meant to be a standalone event, but have an aftermath linking the celebration of the different Drylands Schools and gathering together some of their participants into a facilitated network such as a community of practice, with further development.

FAO will provide access to this network after the Drylands School, using any of the key communities already ongoing (the D-groups and [DSL-IP Communities of Practice](#), the Making Every Voice Count for Adaptive Management (MEV-CAM) or the Nurturing Community of Knowledge Practice for Women in Dryland Forests and Agrosilvopastoral Systems (WeCaN). Drylands School participants are also welcome to join the FAO e-learning academy and other FAO resources.

COFO WG and FAO Dryland's team are currently planning a follow-up program that already started with the previous Drylands Schools, tracking down participants and asking them for feedback and preparing a follow-up article to be posted online.

